



United Nations Association in Canada - Vancouver Branch

L'association canadienne pour les Nations Unies – Région de Vancouver

PRESIDENTS' REPORT FOR 2025-2026

UNAC-Vancouver Annual General Meeting - May 21, 2026



INTRODUCTION

As Co-Presidents of the Vancouver Branch of the UN Association in Canada (UNAC-V), Koyali Burman and Lauren Farmer are pleased to report that the state of our organization remains strong, with our branch expanding in its outreach and engagement within the Metro Vancouver community. This year, we adopted a hybrid model with some of our events and meetings taking place in person and others taking place online. Our 2025-2026 programming supported our mission to engage and educate people in Metro Vancouver on the goals and values of the United Nations, including the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). All our events are intended to advance Goal 17 “Partnerships for the Goals”. Below you will find a summary of the work of the UNAC-V Board from June 2025 to May 2026.





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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

UNAC-V acknowledges that we live, work, and hold our events on the traditional and unceded territories of the qíçə́y (Katzie), q̓wɑ:ńłə́ń (Kwantlen), kwíkʷə́łəm (Kwikwetlem), máthxwi (Matsqui), x̣ẉməθkʷə́yəm (Musqueam), qíqéyt (Qayqayt), Semiahmoo, Sk̓wx̓wú7mesh Úxwumixw (Squamish), scə́wəθən məsteyəx̣w (Tsawwassen), and sə́lilwə́təł (Tsleil-Waututh).

As the United Nations Association in Canada Vancouver Branch, we are dedicated to addressing and raising awareness of critical global and local challenges, some of which deeply affect Indigenous Peoples here in Canada, and we recognize the importance of grounding our efforts in truth, respect, and reconciliation.

In our roles as Co-Presidents, we commit to ensuring that our work amplifies Indigenous voices and perspectives, and that we uphold—when possible—the intent of the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP) here in Metro Vancouver.



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EVENTS

John Gibbard Memorial Award (October 19, 2025)

The John Gibbard Memorial Award recognizes youth leadership and commitment to advancing peace, human rights, and the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals. Established in memory of Vancouver educator and UN supporter John Gibbard (1901–1990), the award is jointly presented each year on UN Day by the United Nations Association in Canada – Vancouver Branch and the Unitarian Church of Vancouver.

In 2025, the award was presented to Edgar Villanueva Cruz for his contributions to Indigenous economic development and youth empowerment in Canada. As a Coach Mentor for Bears' Lair Dream Camps, he supports Indigenous youth through entrepreneurship, financial literacy, and leadership training. Edgar also leads the Future Minerals Leadership Council Pilot Project, which engages young leaders, First Nations, industry, and government in addressing environmental challenges in mining and resource development. His work reflects the award's purpose of recognizing young individuals dedicated to creating a more just, peaceful, and sustainable world.



Photo: Edgar Villabuena accepting his award with his family

Renate Shearer Award 2025 (December 10, 2025)

In recognition of United Nations Human Rights Day, observed worldwide on December 10th, we recognized 411 Seniors Centre Society as the recipient for the Renate Shearer Award for Human Rights for 2025. The event was hosted by UNAC-V in collaboration with BCCIC.



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There were over 30 people in attendance. The Vancouver Branch since 1988 has been in partnership alongside others, recognizing individuals or organizations working to promote human rights locally and globally. We are particularly enthusiastic about awarding 411 Seniors Centre Society as the UN under the leadership of World Health Organization (WHO) is celebrating the decade of Healthy Aging [2021-2030].

This is the first time that UNAC-V has recognized the rights of seniors in 37 years of its existence. To celebrate the UN Decade of Healthy Aging (2021 - 2030), UNAC-V wanted to focus on the positive contributions and aspirations of older persons and their role in building resilient societies. The 411 Seniors Centre Society is a membership driven, well known group in the Lower Mainland, promoting high quality of life and vibrant inclusive community for older adults. They offer a variety of programs including drop-in services, referral programs, events, workshops, income tax preparation, etc. The Centre works towards creating an inclusive community of informed and connected older adults in the Lower Mainland.





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Richard Splane Lecture 2026 (January 22, 2026)

Each year, the Dr. Richard Splane Lecture is held at the University of British Columbia's Vancouver Campus as a joint collaboration between the UBC School of Social Work and the United Nations Association in Canada – Vancouver Branch. The lecture honours the memory of Richard Splane, a leader in Canadian social policy. Richard Splane was a Professor Emeritus of the University of British Columbia,



beginning his academic career at McMaster University, pursuing studies in economics, history and social work at the University of Toronto and social administration at the London School of Economics. He is regarded as the "principal architect" of the Canada Assistance Plan. He served as Canada's representative on the UNICEF Board and was a member of the United Nations' Expert Group on Social Welfare Policy and Planning. In 1973, he was recruited by the University of British Columbia, as a Professor in the School of Social Work, where he served until his retirement in 1982.

For the 2026 Richard Splane Lecture, we chose to mark the 25th year of the UN Resolution 1325 on Women, Peace and Security. This event featured four prominent leaders whose work influences peace and security worldwide. The lecture centered women's perspectives on conflict, resilience, and human security, emphasizing approaches that advance more equitable futures.

The four speakers were:

- **Katrina Leclerc:** A multi-award-winning peacebuilder, published researcher, and globally recognized specialist on the intersections of Women, Peace and Security (WPS) and Youth, Peace and Security (YPS). Part-Time Professor, Saint Paul University and Sessional Lecturer, University of Winnipeg.
- **Angela Marie MacDougall:** Executive Director of Battered Women's Support Services Association, Vancouver. She is an expert panellist at Canadian Femicide Observatory for Justice and Accountability, a founding member of Feminists Deliver, a long-standing



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member of Vancouver's Women's Memorial March, and a founding member of Intersectional Feminist Justice Research and Organizing Collaborative.

- **Megan MacKenzie, PhD:** Simons Chair in International Law and Human Security at Simon Fraser University and CoDirector of the Canadian National Research Network on Women Peace and Security. She is known for her work on gender, war, and reimagining security beyond militarism.
- **Ellen Woodsworth:** Co-Chair of the Women's International League for Peace and Freedom Canada, an active writer with QUIRK-E, Founder and Matriarch of Women Transforming Cities, a former Vancouver City Councillor and long activist using an intersectional lens.

The panel discussion was moderated by Lauren Farmer, UNAC-V Co-President and included remarks by Dean Clare Crowston - Dean of the Faculty of Arts, Dr. Lea Caragata - Director of the School of Social Work, Patsy George - Past President of UNAC-V, and Donna Baines - Professor, UBC School of Social Work. The event was well attended and positively received by over 100 guests virtually and in-person on the UBC Vancouver Campus.





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Think Global Link Local 2026 (March 6, 2026)

TGLL is an annual networking event connecting undergraduate students and recent grads with non-governmental, non-profit, civil society and public service organizations from the Vancouver and Lower Mainland BC region. Each organization hosts a table with a designated representative serving as the Table Captain. These Table Captains provide insights about their organization, share information about available opportunities, and engage with attendees. Attendees have ample opportunities to network with various organizations throughout the duration of the event.

The organizations promote the UN's SDGs, though all of them are active in Vancouver and have a global perspective. In 2026, the 12th annual TGLL, the event was held at the Holiday Inn Vancouver Centre. Our keynote speaker was Minister Jessie Sunner. Minister Sunner was first elected as the MLA for Surrey-Newton in 2024. Minister Sunner was appointed Minister of Post Secondary Education and Future Skills in July 2025. She previously served as Parliamentary Secretary for Anti-Racism Initiatives. Prior to being elected to the legislature, she was a human rights lawyer and trade unionist for the Hospital Employees' Union. She has been a strong advocate in the Surrey community for years, serving as Vice President of the Surrey Women's Centre and Vice Chair of the Surrey Police Board. Minister Sunner has also served on the boards of the South Asian Bar Association, BC College of Social Workers, and the United Nations Association in Canada. She holds a Bachelor of Arts in Criminology from Simon Fraser University and a Law Degree from the University of Calgary.





We had 12 organizations participate in the event. The MCs for the event were our UNAC-V Co-Presidents, Koyali Burman and Lauren Farmer. Additional speakers included George Somerwill, Past President of UNAC-V, Larissa Petrillo, Special Advisor, Strategic Initiatives – Office of the Provost at Kwantlen Polytechnic University (KPU). Students went through 3 rounds of networking where they were able to connect with organizations representatives at tables around the room. The event ended with a raffle draw for 7 coffee dialogues with UNAC-V and KPU team members, including Patsy George, George Somerwill, Darrel Filwood, Rosio Godomar, Larissa Petrillo, Koyali Burman, and Lauren Farmer.

TGLL is organized through a partnership between UNAC Vancouver and KPU. KPU students assist with all aspects of the organization and running of the event as part of their studies. Additionally, the students help to market the event and provide technical support on the day of the event. These KPU students are thanked for the substantial time and effort that they put into making this event a success. Each year, we receive feedback from attendees and Table Captains on how important this event is for networking. Attendees are able to get advice and feedback from organizations on how to start a career in the non-profit sector and UN. This event often connects attendees with organizations that are looking for volunteers and employees. Some attendees of the event also reach out to UNAC-V for opportunities to further engage in our work, and some also join UNAC-V's Advisory Council. This annual networking event promotes SDG 17: Partnership for the Goals. The Table Captains represented diverse organizations working to achieve the 17 SDGs in Canada, and globally.





UN SDG Day (April 29, 2026)

The United Nations Sustainable Development Goals Day was a special occasion and the first event organized by the United Nations Association in Canada Vancouver Branch dedicated to raising awareness and inspiring action toward a more sustainable, inclusive, and equitable world. Held at Vancouver City Hall on April 29, the event focused on the theme: **“Migration, Belonging in Urban Spaces – Global North & South.”** The event was supported by the City Staff.

The program began with greetings from UNAC-V Co-President Koyali Burman, followed by messages from George Somerwill and Aki Temiseva. One of the highlights of the event was the keynote remarks delivered by Nigel Fisher. Nigel Fisher is a Canadian humanitarian and international development leader who served in several senior roles with the United Nations, including as Assistant Secretary-General. Over his career, he worked extensively in humanitarian response, refugee support, and international development across regions affected by conflict and displacement.

The event was highly engaging, particularly during the interactive panel segment featuring Nenad Rava (UN Director of Program/SDG Fund), Jennifer Marchbank (Prof/Chair, SFU Gender Studies), and Erin Williams (Director, Programs Asia Pacific of Canada). The discussion focused on migration and belonging, exploring the key challenges and opportunities involved in making “belonging” a reality in rapidly changing urban environments shaped by migration. The gathering provided an important platform for dialogue on migration, inclusion, urban belonging, and global solidarity, bringing together community members, scholars, and advocates to reflect on sustainable and equitable futures.



Rosemary Brown Lecture 2026 (May 21, 2026)

The Rosemary Brown Lecture 2026, held following the AGM, focuses on advancing gender equality and social justice while fostering dialogue and collaboration on issues of diversity, inequality, human rights, and political and community activism. The session began with a commemoration of the life and legacy of Rosemary Brown by Patsy George, Honorary Director of the UNAC-V, followed by a discussion on the context of migration and gender justice in Canada by Koyali Burman, Co-President of UNAC-V, and this year's lecture topic, "Settlement of LGBTQ Refugees in GVGVA: Issues and Support." The lecture is offered by Jennifer Marchbank, Professor and Chair, Gender, Sexuality and Women's Studies, Simon Fraser University, BC Canada.



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The lecture explored the challenges faced by LGBTQ refugees during the settlement process in the Greater Vancouver area, as well as the community resources, advocacy initiatives, and support systems available to assist them.



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OTHER COMMITTEES

Website Development 2025-2026

UNAC-V recognized the need for a fresh, modern look to revitalize its website and support future digital initiatives. To achieve this, website volunteers were recruited to contribute to both design and development.

The website was developed through a collaborative effort between the volunteers and the UNAC-V Board, particularly the website committee: Axel, Dariel, Lauren, George, Sameer, and Soon-Lan. Additional support was provided by committee leads across various UNAC-V initiatives, who contributed essential content.

Content across the website was reduced to be more meaningful, impactful, and reflective of UNAC-V's values. The final deliverables include the Home, About, Events, SDGs, Get Involved, Resources, and Contact pages, along with additional pages supporting specific events and functionalities. You can see the new website HERE: <https://unacvancouver.org/>

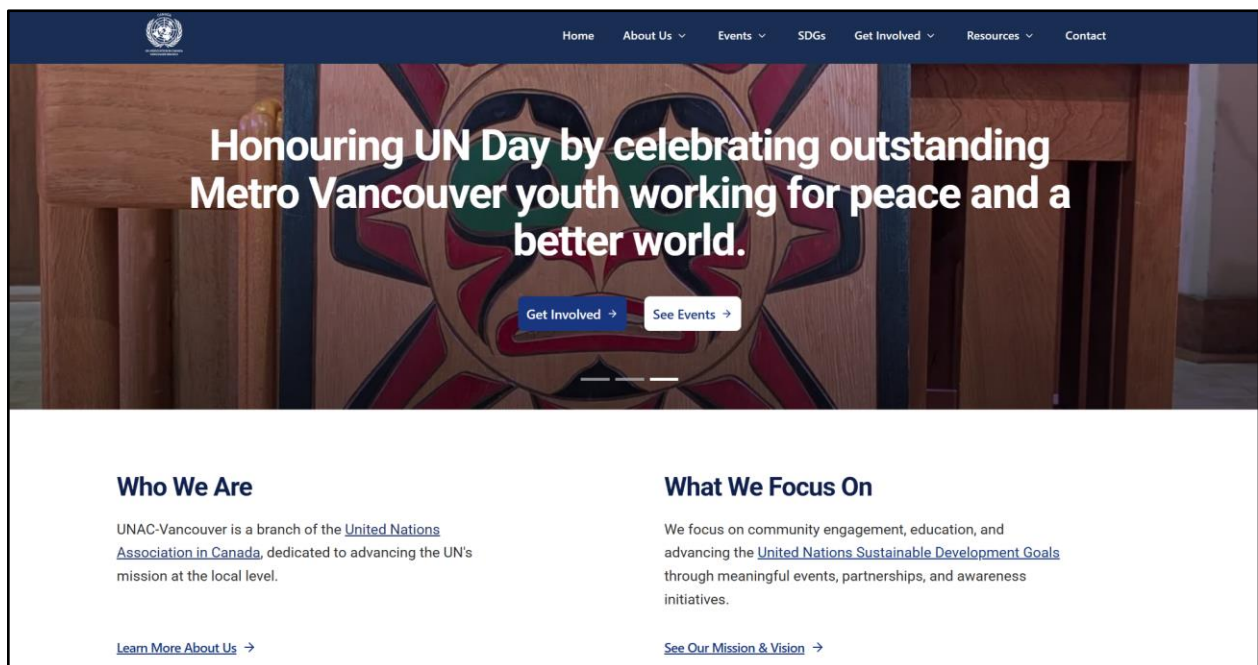


Photo: New UNAC-V website screenshot



Volunteer Engagement

Over the 2025–2026 reporting period, UNAC-V's volunteer base continued to grow steadily, supported by ongoing outreach and improved onboarding processes.

Volunteer Growth and Onboarding

Our primary volunteer coordination platform is a Slack workspace, used to connect individuals who express interest in volunteering with the branch. From 2025 to April 2026, 14 new volunteers were added, bringing total membership to 80. An additional 15 prospective volunteers have been invited and are currently in the process of joining the workspace.

Volunteer inquiries continue to be received through both the UNAC-V branch email and the national office contact, in addition to our online intake channels.

In October 2025, the Board implemented a Volunteer Survey to better understand active engagement within the volunteer pool. The survey received 44 responses and provided useful insight into volunteer participation and interests.

We have also worked with our web developer to integrate a volunteer intake form directly into the UNAC-V website. This allows for more consistent and centralized onboarding of new volunteers.

Engagement and Platform Considerations

While Slack remains our primary coordination tool, engagement levels have been variable throughout 2025. A number of volunteers are youth or students who may be less familiar with the platform or experience barriers accessing it consistently.

UNAC-V previously managed a Facebook volunteer group (2019–2023) before transitioning to Slack to better align with changing user preferences. However, given ongoing shifts in platform usage and volunteer turnover, it may be beneficial to explore alternative systems or a more centralized engagement hub that better reflects current volunteer needs and preferences.



Future Volunteer Development

A recurring challenge is the limited capacity for meaningful volunteer engagement outside of Board roles. Many volunteers are students with limited availability, making sustained governance participation difficult.

To address this, UNAC-V is exploring the development of annual volunteer workshops or similar programming. These initiatives would provide more accessible opportunities for skills development, engagement with UNAC-V's mission, and exposure to the work of the United Nations more broadly.

Social Media Engagement

Over the 2025–2026 reporting period (January 2025 to April 2026), UNAC-V maintained active communications across Facebook, Instagram, and LinkedIn. Content focused primarily on three themes: event promotion, recognition of UN days, and original design and written content highlighting UN-related issues and programming.

Overall, engagement increased across platforms, with the strongest growth observed on Facebook and Instagram.

Facebook

Facebook remained our largest platform, with follower numbers remaining relatively stable at approximately 1,295 (a 0.5% increase over the previous cycle). Our audience is primarily female (75%), with the largest age group being 25–34 (41.9%).

Geographically, 86.3% of followers are based in Canada, with nearly half located in the City of Vancouver (48.9%), and the remainder largely distributed across surrounding municipalities such as Burnaby.

Engagement peaked during the fall and winter months, with the highest level of interaction occurring on January 20, 2026. Overall, Facebook engagement



increased significantly over the reporting period, including an 82.4% increase in interactions and a 256.6% increase in views, likely reflecting heightened activity during peak programming periods, particularly in March 2026.

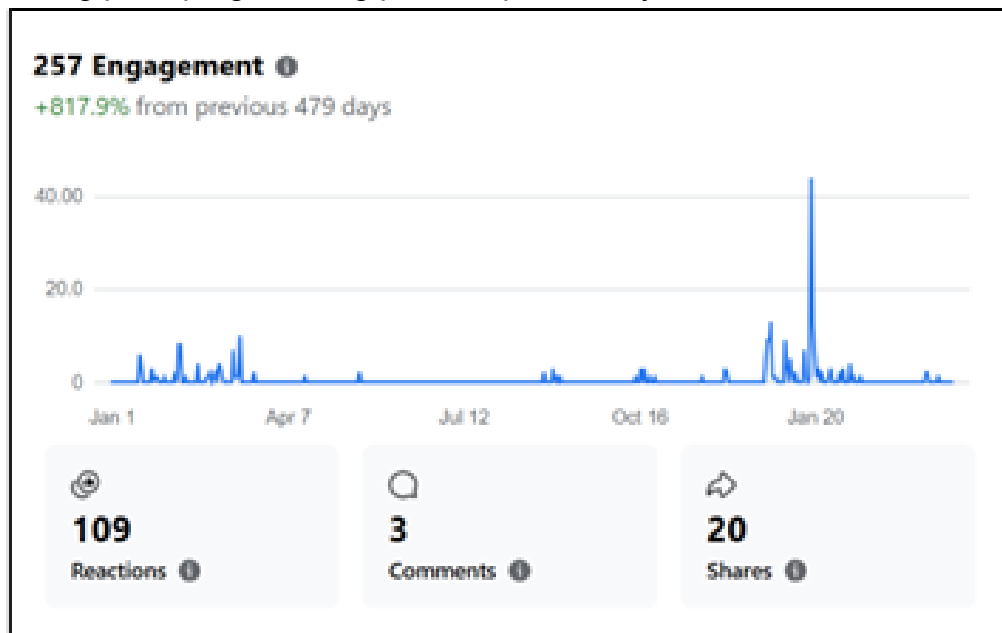


Photo: Facebook engagement from 2025 to early 2026

Instagram

Instagram followers increased from 1,722 to 1,866, representing a gain of 144 followers over the reporting period. The platform audience is similarly predominantly female (65.8%), with the largest age group being 25–34 (45%), followed by 35–44 (26.7%).

Youth engagement (ages 18–24) currently represents 9.1% of combined Instagram and Facebook audiences. This suggests potential for further growth in younger demographics through targeted programming and outreach.

Facebook and Instagram content are now cross-integrated, allowing for simultaneous post distribution across both platforms.



X (Twitter) and LinkedIn

On X (formerly Twitter), follower numbers declined slightly from 1,152 to 1,109. Given comparatively lower engagement on this platform, UNAC-V has shifted its focus toward LinkedIn to better align with its professional and policy-oriented audience base.

LinkedIn continues to be used for targeted outreach and organizational visibility within the non-profit and public service sectors.

Event Promotion

UNAC-V has several key annual events, listed above. TGLL, which is our key networking event, usually sells out, so it's always imperative that we work together as a team to organize the event on schedule and in harmony as a team.

2026's TGLL occurred on March 6th, 2026. This year's TGLL was supported by designing a dedicated poster for promotion and creating table captain posts on social media to promote the event. Our sponsorship team and other volunteers provided strong support for our communications and promotional efforts. Thanks to this, TGLL was once again sold out this year.

2025 was also the first year when UNAC-V sent out Christmas greeting cards to our members. Sending out these types of communications is a great way for our branch to consistently engage with our membership.



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Partnerships 2025-2026

UNAC-V has been actively engaging with the Metro Vancouver community to build new partnerships that support and advance our organization's mission. Over the past year, a notable collaboration was with the Immigrant Services Society of BC (ISSofBC), which generously hosted two of our events at their facilities. We also sponsored a [Canadian High Schools Model United Nations \(CAHSUM\)](#) event in April 2026, which helps bring together over 1,300 students and educators to conferences. We also participated in several virtual events organized by the BC Council for International Cooperation (BCCIC), as well as an in-person gathering hosted by BCCIC that featured staff from Global Affairs Canada and the Honourable Randeep Sarai as guests.

Looking ahead, we aim to further strengthen and expand our collaborations with these organizations. UNAC-V also continues to cultivate longstanding partnerships with the SFU School of International Studies, the UBC School of Social Work, the Unitarian Church of Vancouver, and Kwantlen Polytechnic University's NGO and Non-Profit Studies Program.



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Photo: Koyali Burman and Lauren Farmer at an in-person BCCIC Event



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THANK YOU & How to Donate

All UNAC-V Branch events and activities are made possible through donations from the public, membership fees and fundraising events. The Vancouver Branch is entirely volunteer-run. We appreciate and encourage your continued support through membership or a donation at <https://www.canadahelps.org/en/dn/46443>

Always identify in the messages section your intention to be affiliated with the UNAC-V Branch. Thank you for a great year! We look forward to sharing the highlights of 2026-2027 with you at next year's Annual General Meeting.